

From the workshop, it is quite clear that if you can compromise on the sound quality but want lower file sizes, then you will have to stick to MP3. If you are looking for a mid-sized file with decent audio quality, then opt for Ogg or AAC. For lossless encoding, only Windows Media Audio lets you do that and as seen the file size is not much different from the original .wav file.

From our listening tests, we concluded that the AAC and Ogg files were comparable in sound quality with each other while the MP3 file did feel to be missing something. Nevertheless, if you are not a fussy listener then you can make do with any of these codecs. For the fussy ones, stick to WMA or AAC Lossless.

Newer Formats

This is the age of digital music. Since the appearance of Compact Disc or CD, music has gone digital. In a nutshell, music is stored on a CD in bits or digital numbers which is then played back on a speaker. This process involves deciphering of the digital samples to analogue sound that drives the speakers using a Digital to Analog Converter (DAC). However, similar to the CD, there is a size limitation of the Audio CD.

This is where the newer formats such as DVD-Audio and Super Audio CD (SACD) step in. DVD-Audio aims to utilize the huge amount of space that it has to increase the sampling rate and to record data in surround sound rather than in stereo. Ditto for the SACD. Let us look at what these formats have in store for us.

DVD-Audio

DVD-Audio is yet another development of the DVD Forum, the group of companies that decides what should be considered a standard in the DVD arena in the years to come. The main advantage of DVD-Audio over the standard CD is the impressive audio quality. The table ahead will illustrate the differences between these two formats and you can make out the difference by yourselves.